

- *Siding*: What is the condition of the siding? Does it have any rotten spots, missing boards, cracking, or peeling?
- *Roof*: Go to the south side of the house and look at the shingles. The south side gets the most sun, and curling or buckling can be an indication that the roof needs work.
- *Gutters*: What is the condition of the gutters? Do they have downspouts that direct water away from the home? Do they have any holes? Is vegetation growing in them? Do trees overhang them?
- *Garage door*: Does the garage door open and close easily? Do the safety sensors work properly? Try to close the door and wave your hand in front of the sensor—it should stop the door and reverse to open again.
- *Lawn and yard*: How does the grass look? Are there any dead trees or bushes? Is the landscaping an absolute nightmare? Is this a yard that *you* would be willing to maintain in the future?
- *Slope*: Does the ground slope downward from the home? This is important to direct water away from the home, not into it.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Ask your agent to set you up on the MLS, and narrow down houses within your price range using the items on your “must-haves” list. You’ll want to receive these listings via email once per day to start, then immediately when you’re ready to purchase.
- Bring your list of must-haves, nice-to-haves, and deal breakers to each property. If you like what you see, start trying to notice the worst things about the property. If you *still* like what you see, use your self-directed pre-inspection list to get a really good understanding of the condition the property is in. And remember, none of this is a substitute for a real inspection—you’ll still need an expert’s opinion.
- On average, it takes thirty to forty-five days of searching to find a house on which you want to make an offer, but that’s just an average. If you are under or over this timeline, don’t panic—you know what